

Module 11

Socially Responsible Marketing

Transcript Knowledge Clips — Detailed Explanations

Based on lectures by Prof. Tine De Bock, KU Leuven

1. Introduction

This document provides a detailed explanation of the key concepts covered in the Module 11 video clips on Socially Responsible Marketing, as presented by Professor Tine De Bock of KU Leuven. The module is built around two foundational concepts — **marketing** and **social responsibility** — and how they combine to form a holistic, forward-looking approach to business practice.

As Prof. De Bock explains in the opening clip: *"There are two concepts that immediately come to the forefront when we talk about socially responsible marketing. First of all, there's social responsibility. Secondly, there's 'marketing'. It's kind of hard to introduce you to socially responsible marketing without talking about these two concepts."*

2. What Is Marketing?

2.1 Definition

Marketing has countless definitions, but the module anchors itself to the widely-cited formulation by **Philip Kotler**, often called the 'father of modern marketing':

"Marketing is the process by which companies create value for customers and build strong customer relationships, in order to capture value from customers in return."
— Philip Kotler

Across many definitions, the common thread is that marketing is about **creating value** by identifying, anticipating and satisfying customers' needs and wants — whether those customers are businesses, individual consumers, or other stakeholders. When an organisation creates superior value, it receives value in return (financial results, positive word-of-mouth, brand equity, etc.). Successful marketing is therefore fundamentally about being **customer-centric**.

2.2 The Marketing Process

Kotler's definition frames marketing as a **process**. This process provides a structured sequence of steps organisations follow to create and deliver value:

- **Mission & Environment Analysis:** Organisations first define their mission statement, then analyse the market environment and conduct research on client needs and wants. They assess their own strengths and weaknesses (internal analysis) and identify external opportunities and threats — a classic SWOT analysis.

- **Marketing Strategy:** The insights from the analysis feed into strategy. This involves segmenting the market, choosing a target audience, determining how to **position** the brand or organisation, and setting marketing goals along with an appropriate budget.
- **Marketing Mix (4 Ps):** Strategic choices are translated into tactical decisions across four dimensions — **Product** (branding, features), **Price** (pricing strategy), **Place** (production, distribution channels) and **Promotion** (advertising, PR, digital marketing). Many people equate marketing with advertising, but the 4 Ps show that promotion is only one component.
- **Customer Value & Relationships:** All steps aim at satisfying customer needs, delighting customers, and building profitable long-term relationships — ultimately capturing value from customers in return.

Note: Different textbooks and online resources may use slightly different labels or pictures for the marketing process, but the underlying logic is always the same.

2.3 The Old vs. the New Marketing World

The marketing process described above was established in an era that now looks very different from today's environment. Understanding this shift is essential for appreciating why socially responsible marketing has become so important.

The Old Marketing World:

- Marketers were often obsessed with their own products and focused heavily on sales and short-term financial results.
- Marketing was mainly one-directional: push messages at customers and hope they buy. Empty promises were tolerated.
- The relationship was narrowly defined as company–customer; the broader societal context was largely ignored.
- Social responsibility was barely on the agenda.

The New Marketing World:

- **Technology** has empowered consumers with unprecedented access to information, dramatically raising the bar for honest, relevant marketing.
- **Globalisation** means local companies now compete in a global marketplace, intensifying competition.
- Marketing must be deeply **customer-oriented**, focused on experience and long-term value rather than one-off transactions.
- Value is increasingly **co-created** with customers and wider networks; one-way broadcasting no longer works.

- Customers have more power and increasingly **expect companies to care about social responsibility**.

Prof. De Bock's key message here: even if you hold on to the classical marketing process as a framework, you must shape it to fit the new marketing world. The fundamentals are a starting point, not a fixed blueprint.

3. Social Responsibility

3.1 The Bigger Picture — Doughnut Economics

To frame social responsibility, the module draws on the work of economist **Kate Raworth** and her concept of **Doughnut Economics**. Raworth's framework describes humanity's 21st-century challenge as a double-sided problem:

"To meet the needs of all people within the means of this extraordinary, unique, living planet so that we and the rest of nature can thrive." — Kate Raworth

The 'doughnut' metaphor illustrates a safe and just space for humanity: a **social foundation** (the inner ring — ensuring all people have what they need) and an **ecological ceiling** (the outer ring — staying within planetary boundaries). The goal is to live and do business in the space between these two rings.

3.2 Sustainable Development

The doughnut resonates with the concept of **sustainable development**. In 1983, the UN General Assembly recognised that the human environment and natural resources were deteriorating. This led to the formation of the **Brundtland Commission**, which released its landmark report *Our Common Future* in 1987. The report offered the most widely cited definition of sustainable development:

"Development that meets the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own needs." — The Brundtland Report (1987)

This definition has two core ideas: (1) meeting *current* human needs, and (2) not depleting resources or damaging the environment in ways that prevent *future* generations from meeting their own needs.

3.3 Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)

The United Nations operationalised sustainable development through the **Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)** — a collection of **17 interlinked goals** that form a blueprint for a better and more sustainable future for all. The SDGs were adopted in 2015 and are

intended to be achieved by **2030**. Examples include:

- SDG 2: Zero Hunger
- SDG 5: Gender Equality
- SDG 12: Responsible Consumption and Production
- SDG 13: Climate Action

The SDGs are highly relevant to businesses because they provide a concrete, internationally agreed framework against which organisations can measure and communicate their social and environmental contributions.

3.4 Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) and the 3 Ps

When sustainability thinking is brought into the corporate context it is typically called **Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR)**. CSR is about keeping a healthy balance between the **Triple Bottom Line — People, Planet and Profit** (the 3 Ps):

- **People:** Social impact — fair labour, community wellbeing, inclusion.
- **Planet:** Environmental stewardship — carbon footprint, biodiversity, resource use.
- **Profit:** Financial viability — without which organisations cannot sustain their social and environmental commitments.

4. Socially Responsible Marketing

4.1 Definition

Bringing marketing and social responsibility together yields **socially responsible marketing** (also called sustainable marketing or sustainability marketing). The module deliberately uses the term 'socially responsible' rather than 'sustainable' to avoid narrowing the concept to only environmental issues:

*Socially responsible marketing is the practice of an organisation meeting the needs of its current customers in a **socially and environmentally responsible manner**, without burdening future generations so that they can no longer meet their own needs.*

This definition explicitly echoes the Brundtland definition of sustainable development. Where traditional marketing focused on a dyadic relationship (consumers ↔ organisation), socially responsible marketing adds a third dimension: **societal and environmental well-being**.

4.2 Two Directions of the Marketing–Sustainability Relationship

Prof. De Bock highlights that the relationship between marketing and sustainability can run in two directions, each resulting in a distinct type of socially responsible marketing practice:

Direction 1 — Marketing First, Sustainability Added On:

The organisation starts with its existing marketing approach and investigates how to make it more sustainable. This is the most common approach, typically used by profit-oriented companies that are gradually integrating purpose alongside profit. The marketing process remains central and sustainability is layered on top.

Example: **Sustainable Pricing** — A sustainable price accounts fully for the economic, environmental and social costs of a product's manufacture and marketing, while still providing value for customers and a fair profit for the business. Unlike traditional pricing strategies focused primarily on competitiveness or margin, sustainable pricing strives for a healthier balance between People, Planet and Profit. Other examples include biodegradable or recycled packaging, or manufacturing processes that use fewer resources and produce less waste.

Direction 2 — Sustainability First, Marketing as the Enabler:

Here the organisation's primary reason for existence is to address a social or environmental challenge, and marketing disciplines are used to bring that social responsibility to life. This approach is more common among organisations for which **purpose comes before profit** — non-profits, social enterprises, and many governmental institutions.

Specific marketing disciplines that fall under this direction include:

- **Non-profit marketing and fundraising** — applying marketing techniques to mobilise resources and support for mission-driven organisations.
- **Social marketing** — using marketing to drive *social change* in behaviour (e.g., persuading people to recycle, to stop littering, or to adopt healthier lifestyles).

4.3 Applying Socially Responsible Marketing — The SDG Matrix Exercise

A practical tool introduced in the module is a **Marketing Process × SDG Matrix**. Organisations can use this framework to systematically explore opportunities to align each step of their marketing process with one or more of the 17 SDGs:

- Each **column** represents a step in the marketing process (environment analysis, strategy, product, price, place, promotion).
- Each **row** represents one of the 17 SDGs.

- The organisation then considers how it can align each marketing step with each relevant SDG, filling in concrete actions or commitments.

This matrix makes socially responsible marketing tangible and actionable. It prevents sustainability from remaining a vague aspiration and helps teams identify specific, measurable opportunities across the entire marketing function.

4.4 The Breadth of Socially Responsible Marketing

Socially responsible marketing is an **umbrella term** covering a wide variety of sub-topics and disciplines, all sharing the common thread of the interplay between social responsibility and marketing:

- **Sustainable consumption behaviour** — understanding and influencing how consumers make choices that are more environmentally and socially responsible.
- **Marketing ethics** — the moral principles governing marketing decisions and practices.
- **Social marketing** — using marketing tools to stimulate socially beneficial behaviour change.
- **Non-profit marketing** — marketing in service of mission-driven, non-commercial organisations.
- **Green/environmental marketing** — communicating and delivering environmentally friendly products and processes.

5. Key Takeaways

Prof. De Bock concludes the presentation with a concise summary of the core concepts. These are reproduced and elaborated below:

1. Marketing is a value-creation process.

Marketing is the process by which organisations create value for customers and build strong customer relationships in order to capture value in return. Being customer-centric is central to successful marketing.

2. The marketing world has changed — and so must marketing practice.

The classical marketing process remains a useful framework, but it must be adapted to the realities of the new marketing world: empowered consumers, globalisation, digital technology, and rising expectations around social responsibility.

3. Social responsibility is rooted in sustainable development.

Sustainable development — meeting current needs without compromising future generations — is the cornerstone of social responsibility. The SDGs provide 17 concrete goals that give organisations a clear framework for action.

4. Socially responsible marketing merges both concepts.

An organisation engaged in socially responsible marketing meets current customer needs in a socially and environmentally responsible manner, without burdening future generations. It goes beyond the traditional company–customer dyad to include societal and environmental well-being.

5. The relationship between marketing and sustainability runs in two directions.

Organisations can start with marketing and add sustainability (most common for profit-first companies), or start with sustainability and use marketing to advance it (most common for purpose-first organisations such as non-profits and social enterprises).

6. Socially responsible marketing is a broad, evolving field.

It encompasses social marketing, non-profit marketing, sustainable consumption behaviour, marketing ethics and much more. All these topics share the interplay between social responsibility and marketing.